



Another Open Source mobile OS

Mozilla plans to take its Gecko engine to eventually develop a mobile OS of its own

Rich people of Open Source

founded one of the most successful Open Source projects on the planet, right?

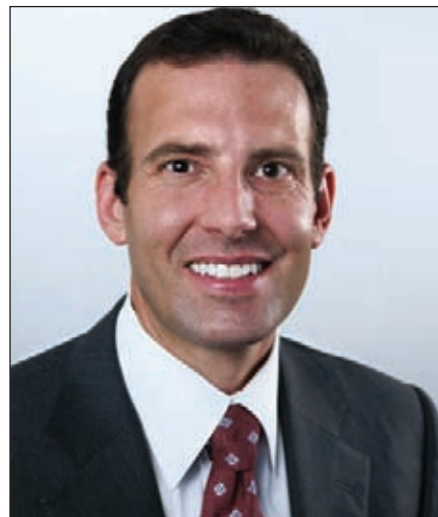
Matt Mullenweg

Another very successful Open Source story of the new world (read: web) is WordPress. The founder of the ubiquitous blogging platform has had a strange success story. He originally came from a non-technical background, studying to be a Jazz Saxophonist. He started dabbling with code with the Open Source b2/cafelog blogging software sometime in 2002 when he was just 18 years old. He later used b2 code base to launch a fork project, and soon enough by 2005 the first version of WordPress was out. The company he started, Automattic, soon had many more projects under its umbrella such as Akismet. WordPress, though Open Source and free to deploy for the most part, has a few substantial revenue sources as reported by www.labnol.org. WordPress offers VIP hosting services to clients like gigaom.com and All Things D. Revenue is also generated via premium accounts, WordPress support and the commercial licence of the Akismet spam filter. All of this can lead to

only one thing. Now 27, Matt Mullenweg's net worth as of 2010 was estimated to be somewhere in the region of \$40 million.

The weird ones

In December 1999, at the height of the dot-com madness, a tiny company called VA Linux Systems came out with its IPO offering. The company combined Linux and Intel-based hardware. Its stock debuted at \$30 a share, but almost instantly rocketed skywards by a staggering 800 per cent! The day closed with VA Linux garnering a market cap of about \$10 billion. Till until at least a decade later it was to remain the biggest first-day gain on the NASDAQ. In contrast to its \$10 billion market cap, the company's net revenues until just a month prior were under \$15 million and assets probably twice that - a big bubble indeed. What's important in the context of this article though, is the effect this rally had on the promoters of the company. Overnight, CEO Larry Augustin's holding and stock options took his net worth to \$1.7 billion. Of course, as all bubbles this one had to burst soon enough too. Valuations returned back to ground



Larry Augustin

level, VA Linux went on a fated downward decline. But the story didn't end there. Soon the company changed its name to SourceForge, (sound familiar?) and then again to Geeknet. Augustin may have had a tumultuous path since he left Stanford, but he seems to not have left his Open Source roots and serves as CEO of SugarCRM, again one of the most successful Open Source projects around. ■

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